

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2008-09-30

To an individual Bahá'í

251 41 30 September 2008 To an individual Bahá'í Dear Bahá'í Friend, 41.1 . . . You ask whether the current focus on the core activities

implies that other activities that have been pursued in the past, such as firesides, deepenings, proclamation activities, and travel teaching, are to be abandoned, and you question whether visiting believers and maintaining Assemblies in remote places are still important. You also express concern over what you perceive to be a shift in the locus of decision making away from elected bodies to appointed institutions, which has given you the impression “that believers at the grass roots are no longer being asked what they think, but are more or less being told what they should think.”

41.2 As you know, during the time of the Guardian, emphasis

was placed on establishing the Faith throughout the world and in raising up the administrative institutions that would provide the foundation for the prosecution of the Divine Plan. As the House of Justice observed in its Ridván 2000 message, this task has been essentially completed. The Cause has now entered a stage in its organic development in which it is necessary to prepare the community for entry by troops and, beyond that, mass conversion. The current series of global teaching Plans have focused the energies of the Bahá'ís on stimulating the processes of growth and community development at the level of the cluster, and the friends have been encouraged to teach the Faith where they live. Those clusters with larger Bahá'í populations have been selected for close attention with the expectation that they can more rapidly advance, and the lessons learned can then be applied to other clusters. This does not mean that believers from clusters with smaller Bahá'í populations are to be neglected or that they need to wait in order to initiate their own programs of growth. On the contrary, they 252 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION should vigorously engage themselves in the development of the core activities, enthusiastically pursuing every avenue available to involve an ever-increasing number of non-Bahá'ís in their activities.

41.3 The emphasis on the two essential movements of the Plan—

the development of human resources through participation in the courses of the training institute and the progression of clusters through a series of developmental stages that result in the initiation of programs of intensive growth—does not require that activities that have been pursued in the past be suspended. Rather, what it calls for is that those activities be assessed in the context of the needs, resources, and priorities of a cluster and that thoughtful decisions be made in the light of experience, with consideration being given to the most effective use of the resources available and the value of systematization.

While the House of Justice has emphasized that it is important for the friends to maintain focus on the essential activities of the Plan, it clarified in its message of 27 December 2005 to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors that “to maintain focus does not imply that special needs and interests are neglected, much less that essential activities are

dropped in order to accommodate others. Clearly, there are a host of elements that comprise Bahá'í community life, shaped over the decades, which must be further refined and developed." The maintenance of Assemblies in remote areas constitutes one such special need that is not to be neglected. Yet here, too, the accomplishment of this objective would be greatly facilitated by employing the instruments of the current Plan, which have proven so effective in fostering the growth and development of the community.

41.4 Essential aspects of advancing the process of entry by

troops are the strengthening and development of the three protagonists of the Plans—the individual believer, the institutions, and the local community—and the development of a culture of learning. Mistakes will be made as the friends adjust to the new requirements. But the House of Justice is confident that as experience and the capacity for learning increase, a greater measure of coherence among activities related to the expansion and consolidation of the Cause will be achieved, the complementary nature of the roles of the institutions of the Faith will be more clearly understood and the collaboration that is to take place among them will become more effective. It 253

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]